

MADAGASCAN DRY FOREST

Evolution in isolation

Madagascar is the world's fourth largest island. In the 135 million years since it separated from the continent of Africa, its plants and animals have diversified, producing a unique collection. The natural vegetation in the drier, western part of this tropical island is dominated by dry deciduous forests interspersed with wetlands. The geology of the area is mostly karst, a type of limestone, which means that surface water rapidly drains into underground rivers.

Baobabs, lemurs, and chameleons

Madagascar's trees include the gigantic baobabs—six species of which are endemic—and the spiny, succulent pachypodiums. The dry forests once extended from the coastal plain to about 2,600 ft (800 m) of altitude, but have been widely replaced by grazing pasture. Today, only three percent of the original forests remain, and they

are of global ecological importance because of the hundreds of endemic plants and animals they support. These include lemurs—a group of primates found only in Madagascar. The forests are also home to a range of specialist insectivores and carnivores, and the world's most endangered tortoise, the plowshare tortoise—and two-thirds of the world's chameleon species.

Some of the more unusual wildlife is partly protected from persecution by traditional beliefs that place a *fady*, or taboo, on certain species. However, this has not protected the animals from the indirect threat of forest clearance for firewood and charcoal production, and some are still collected for the pet trade.



WORLD'S RAREST TORTOISE

This critically endangered tortoise has a wild population of just 200 adults, living in scraps of rocky scrub where they feed on grasses. Eggs and young are predated by introduced bush pigs, and individuals are still poached for the pet trade.

PLOWSHARE TORTOISE

MINIATURE MARVEL

With a total length of 2 in (5 cm), it is no surprise the dwarf chameleon escaped scientific attention until as recently as 1996. One of the world's smallest reptiles, it hunts in the leaf litter at night and climbs into low leafy branches to hide by day.

DWARF CHAMELEON

95% of

Baobabs can store up to 26,400 gallons (100,000 liters) of water in their trunk

THE MAGNIFICENT SEVEN

Madagascar's seven species of baobab are a symbol of the island. During wet periods, the fibrous wood swells with stored water, causing the trunk to bloat. Baobabs are deciduous, and shed their leaves in the dry season to reduce water loss.

BAOBABS